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In Somerville, triple-checking quirk of law

New state regulations could allow skinny three-story homes in backyards

By Spencer Buell
GLOBE STAFF

SOMERVILLE — This city is proud of its many triple-deckers, the entry points to homeownership and affordable apartments for generations.

Somerville was also early to embrace the tiny backyard homes known as "accessory dwelling units" as a way to combat the current housing crisis.

But new state regulations that allow builders to create — and require cities to approve — a combination of the two is testing the limits of this city's warm feelings for both.

The new Massachusetts ADU law, city officials say, is raising the specter of tiny triple-deckers, mini versions of the real thing, cropping up in the tight confines of their urban backyards.

Absurd an image as it may seem, a quirk in the regulations would seem to explicitly give Somerville, and possibly other municipalities as well, no choice but to allow construction of the three-story knockoffs.

Despite a deep ethos in favor of new housing, Somerville is now concerned it is losing control over its own backyards.

"It's really bizarre," said Ben Ewen-Campen, a Somerville city councilor and soon-to-be state representative. "The state has created a situation where by right you can put a miniature triple-decker behind every triple-decker. I just can't believe that was the legislative intent."

The law in effect since 2025 al-

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PHOTOS BY JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF



ROWING TO GLORY ON THE CHARLES

Above, a rower from Cambridge Rindge and Latin School tapped the sign reading "Row Like A Champion Today" inside the Cambridge Boat Club during day three of the annual Head of the Charles Regatta in Cambridge on Sunday. At left, members of Norcal Crew competed in the Men's Youth Eights race. Among Sunday's results, the Dutch surged past Harvard by half a second in a thrilling finish in the premier men's race. **C3.**

Lodging, with a sense of place and history

Entrepreneur builds a regional empire of boutique hotels

By Christopher Muther
GLOBE STAFF

Rob Blood, founder of the fast-growing hotel chain Lark, didn't start with a grand plan to turn fussy, porcelain-doll-and-doily-filled New England bed and breakfasts into stylish boutique hotels. He didn't even start with a hospitality degree.

He developed his now-winning formula by learning the ropes for a year at a Nantucket inn, then by taking a chance on buying an old, nine-room Kennebunkport property at age 28.

"It was like business school for me," Blood said. "When you're an innkeeper, you do a bit of everything. You do the marketing, build your own website, make the pancakes, and go to Shaw's to do the shopping. I didn't have a lot of experience, and I think that actually helped."

He's come a long way from flipping pancakes in Kennebunkport. With his partner Megan Kennedy, Blood, 51, has built an enviable collection of design-forward, award-winning hotels that began in the Northeast, now stretch down the East Coast, and have expanded to Texas and California. Blood has also branched into hotel management and development, opened a hotel design studio called Elder & Ash, and grown Lark into a chain with $150 million in annual revenue while overseeing a real estate portfolio valued at nearly $1 billion.

This year alone, Lark opened

LARK, Page A7

PATRIOTS HOLD OFF JETS IN 26-19 VICTORY

New England Patriots wide receiver DeMario Douglas celebrated after scoring a touchdown during the second quarter of the game Sunday against the New York Jets in Foxborough. After three linemen came off the field with injuries, the team appeared to be moving forward with a makeshift offensive line. **C1.**



DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF

Amazon's bid for drones hits turbulence

Westborough group resists plans for center to launch airborne service

By Yogev Toby
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

WESTBOROUGH — Stephanie Stuchlik lives about a mile from Amazon's colossal warehouse, where dozens of blue-vested drivers haul packages every day. But at home, under a clear sky in her lush backyard, she doesn't notice any of that action.

Soon, her reality could transform, as Amazon plans to launch a fleet of 83-pound delivery drones that would zip overhead — up to 1,000 times a day.

"It's going to ruin our town," said the 40-year-old mother of two, who works in real estate. "It will ruin how I use my home to the point that I would want to move, frankly."

That science fiction-esque reality is approaching fast. Too fast, for some residents, like Stuchlik, who are chasing any way to hit the brakes on the project. Amazon wants to convert a parking lot at the Westborough Fulfillment Center into an Amazon Prime Air Drone Delivery launching pad. From there, drones would fly in and out to deliver small packages to more than a dozen cities and towns in a 7.5-mile radius that would also affect parts of Worcester and Shrewsbury.

According to Amazon, Westborough drones are

WESTBOROUGH, Page A10

GOP nominee ends campaign after car crash

Lt. governor candidate arrested on OUI charge

By Kelly Garrity and Chris Van Buskirk
GLOBE STAFF

Shawn Oliver, the Republican Party's nominee for the No. 2 seat in state government, suspended his campaign Sunday hours after he was charged with drunken driving, upending the GOP's ticket with just weeks until Election Day.

Oliver, a New Bedford Republican, ended his lieutenant governor campaign after his running mate, GOP gubernatorial nominee Michael Minogue, pressured him to step aside.

New Bedford police said Oliver drove into five parked vehicles late Saturday night, flipping his own vehicle.

"After careful reflection, I have made the decision to suspend my campaign for Lieutenant Governor," Oliver said in a statement shared Sunday afternoon by a spokesperson for the state Republican Party. "This election is too important to be overshadowed by personal matters. I want to sincerely thank everyone who has supported me throughout this journey and ask that my family's privacy be respected during this difficult time."

With early voting already underway and hundreds of thousands of people already having sub-

OLIVER, Page A10

President Emmanuel Macron of France said he would seek to lower gas prices, a day after some of the worst riots in decades in the country. **A3.**

Former MIT biologist David Sabatini spoke after a jury last week awarded him $6 million in damages in his sexual harassment defamation lawsuit. **B1.**

Beth Israel Deaconess Medical Center and Dana-Farber Cancer Institute will each house different portions of the breast cancer treatment process, beginning a new phase in their partnership. **D1.**

Matthew Farwell's federal trial will resume Monday, with testimony from an FBI agent who helped investigate Sandra Birchmore's death. **B1.**

Loose leaf

Monday: Rays with a breeze. High 55-60. Low 44-49.
Tuesday: Much the same. High 58-63. Low 44-49.
Sunrise: 7:02 Sunset: 5:56
Obituaries, **B6**
Comics and Weather, **D5-6**

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